



Security Watch

More Windows Woes

The Problem

Two serious vulnerabilities have been reported in most Windows versions, including XP Home and XP Professional.

The first has been rated by security firm Secunia as Extremely Critical, their highest rating for threats. The vulnerability can be exploited to take control of a user's system. It is caused due to a certain error within the handling of animated cursors, and can be exploited via a specially-crafted animated cursor file. Arbitrary code can be executed if the bad guy takes over, and this can happen when you visit a malicious site using Internet Explorer or open a malicious e-mail.

The vulnerability was being *actively exploited* at the time of this writing.

The Solution

Microsoft has released patches for this; the patch for Windows XP SP2 is at <http://tinyurl.com/2fu9gc>. The full list of patch URLs (for other Windows OSes) is at <http://tinyurl.com/2qymgy>.

The second vulnerability is only a notch lower—"Highly Critical"—and that means you'll just have to apply the patches for this one as well. The description of the danger is the same as for the first vulnerability, except, of course, that it works in an entirely different way.

The XP SP2 patch for the "Agent URL Parsing Memory Corruption Vulnerability" is at <http://tinyurl.com/26qvsq>, and the full list of patch URLs is at <http://tinyurl.com/2gge2q>.

HERE COMES GOOGLE

Almost 70% Profit Increase For Search Giant

April is the time when companies take stock of their Q1 performance, and take steps to enhance growth or reverse losses over the rest of the year. This year, investing in Google looks promising, thanks to their 69 per cent rise in profits from Q1 2006. It's still search and the advertising it brings that powers Google, but their whole strategy of diversifying, acquiring and hiring seems to be paying the dividends it's supposed to.

We reported earlier that Microsoft CEO, Steve Ballmer, thought Google's growth strategy was "insane". At a talk in Stanford, Ballmer said, "They (Google) are trying to double in a year. That's insane in my opinion." He was careful enough to add that this didn't mean that Google wouldn't do well. He also pointed to Google's work ethic of allowing people "to do their own thing", and said that it wasn't proven to create "value". For those who don't know, Google demands that engineers spend 20 per cent of their work hours working on projects of their own, no matter how weird. This is perhaps why some of the

coolest things online are at Google Labs.

With Google going from a 10,000+ employee company to 12,000+ in under a year, and posting huge increases in profits, it seems to us that they have got their business model right. Acquiring smaller companies with ideas that fit into the Google way of life also seems to be paying off. But most of all, it's the public perception and Google's image as an innovator that's not afraid to try new and fun things that's helping them. We all want jobs at Google, and we all want to use their products—come to think of it, maybe 69 per cent is nothing compared to the things to come.

We're just dying to hear what Steve Ballmer will say next, after all, it was he who predicted in 2005 that Google would be dead before 2010!

Related

Apparently, it's not always fun at Google. Breaking the myths we've had about Google being the ideal place to work, are two founders of Dodgeball, a mobile social networking site that Google took over back in 2005.

Dennis Crowley and Alex Rainert quit Google in mid-April—Crowley said on a blog, "The whole experience was incredibly frustrating for us, especially as we couldn't convince them that Dodgeball was worth engineering resources, leaving us to

HOT

DRM Dead?



An agreement between EMI and Apple allows the Apple iTunes store to sell all songs owned by EMI Music completely DRM-free, at 256 Kbps AAC—much better quality than was earlier available.

Three To Go

It's only EMI; the rest of the Big Four—Sony BMG, Universal and Time Warner have adopted the wait-and-watch, money-grub-while-you-can attitude. They're not even interested in getting a higher price per non-DRM-ed song. Distressing, this.

NOT



watch as other startups got to innovate in the mobile + social space."

Google's response was posted on the Google blog on CNET:

"Google understands the important role social networking plays in today's mobile ecosystem, and we are constantly looking at ways to provide a great user experience in this area. Dodgeball was an early attempt at understanding user needs in this space and we are continuing to evolve our thinking and our offerings. However, we have nothing to announce at this time."

But it's clear, business is business to Google, so don't think it's all just fun and games, especially if you're being bought over by Google.



One Silly Question

"Your computer is Satan, a Saint or...?"



"My wife!"
Umesh Lella



"It's a dog."
Gavrav Dutta



"A saint."
Anuragha Rao



"Time-pass, or Friend..."
Bhavesh Bhasin



"It's Satan himself!"
Sarang Pahade